

Surrendering Influence: The Effects of Major Power Withdrawal

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Abstract

What happens when a major power retreats from the political order it once sustained? Major powers do not govern their orders uniformly. They maintain them through portfolios of bilateral relationships, adjusting support across protégés as strategic priorities, domestic coalitions, and geopolitical conditions change. I argue that reductions in major-power influence reshape protégé behavior in both the short and long run. As support declines, protégés lose material assistance, diplomatic backing, and access to the institutions through which the patron's preferred order is reproduced. These losses alter the domestic and international incentives that sustain alignment, pushing protégés away from the patron's milieu goals and foreign-policy positions. Using a novel measure of major-minor power influence, I analyze how changes in US and Russian ties with all minor powers from 1950 to 2010 shape domestic institutions, economic policy, and foreign-policy alignment. Decreases in US influence are associated with declines in democracy, human rights protections, judicial independence, US trade, and alignment with US foreign policy. Russian disengagement produces movement in the opposite direction: greater liberal policy implementation and more independent foreign policies. Parallel patterns for Britain, France, and China suggest that major-power retrenchment has consequences not only for abandoned protégés, but also for the scope and content of political orders themselves. These findings speak to debates over hierarchy, great-power competition, and the future of the liberal international order.

US President Trump’s public berating of Ukrainian President Zelenskyy in the Oval Office on February 28, 2025, and his announcement of worldwide ‘reciprocal tariffs’ on April 2, just a few weeks later, shocked analysts and foreign leaders alike (Chyzh 2025; Last 2025). A day after the tariff announcement, Canadian Prime Minister Carney declared that “[t]he eighty-year period when the United States embraced the mantle of global economic leadership—when it forged alliances rooted in trust and mutual respect, and championed the free and open exchange of goods and services—is over” (Last 2025).

While striking in presentation, Trump’s actions were consistent with his longstanding skepticism about the post-World War II liberal international order (LIO), a pillar of US foreign policy. He dismantled USAID, accused NATO of “taking advantage of the US,” questioned the benefits of foreign troop deployments in Germany, Japan, and South Korea, called off military exercises with South Korea, invoked national security to justify economic sanctions against allies, and even threatened to annex Canada, Greenland, and the Panama Canal. Though each of these undermined US global leadership, it is less clear how a US retreat from global influence would affect other participants in the LIO. How should we expect these states to behave without US support? More broadly, what is the impact of major power disengagement on a minor power’s domestic and foreign policies?

A unilateral US withdrawal from its position atop the LIO is hardly the first instance of a major power disengaging from its network of allied and aligned states. The disintegration of the Soviet Union triggered the collapse of global communism and dramatically undercut Russian influence. British and French global influence likewise waned with their relative material power. In each of these cases, the major power’s loss of influence was not geographically uniform: some regions were unaffected, some experienced partial retrenchment, and some were abandoned altogether. France, for instance, withdrew from Indochina in 1954, but maintained its influence in parts of francophone Africa until the last few years (Schraeder 1995; Yang and Kuokštytė 2025).

These cases point to a broader conceptual distinction that motivates this article: between

the level at which a major power formulates strategy and the level at which that strategy is actually experienced by its protégés. The LIO, like the Soviet or British- and French-led orders before it, is not a uniform, system-wide treatment that a major power switches on or off all at once. It is a patron-specific political order that the major power maintains through a portfolio of bilateral relationships (Lake 1996, 2009; Nieman 2016*b*). A major power can formulate a single broad strategic orientation—retrenchment, expansion, competition with a rival—but that orientation becomes politically consequential for any given protégé only through the particular, dyadic changes in support it receives. Retrenchment from the LIO, in other words, need not occur uniformly across all US protégés: it may mean no change for some, marginal adjustment for others, and substantial withdrawal from still others.

I argue that changes in major-power influence have both short- and long-term effects on their protégé states’ domestic and foreign policies. My theoretical framework begins with the premise that major powers sit atop informal, hierarchical networks of protégés. These hierarchies build systems of legitimacy—based on ideology or perceived success—to encourage emulation or deference to a hegemon over specific policy domains without relying exclusively on material capabilities (Wendt and Friedheim 1995; Fordham and Asal 2007; Lake 2009; Kang 2010; Ikenberry 2024). This network generates a loose political order, where protégés vary in their closeness to the major power and the degree to which their policies are influenced. From this vantage point, political orders are not fixed architectures but shifting configurations: their intensity varies over time and across space.

This framework has generated a number of theoretical and empirical insights, but most existing research focuses on cross-sectional variation in the level of major-power influence. That is, this literature asks whether a minor power’s presence in a major power’s informal protégé-network leads to differences in domestic and foreign policy. McDonald (2015), Beardsley et al. (2020), and Wang et al. (2024), for example, demonstrate that membership in a major power’s network affects a minor power’s conflict propensity, trade openness, and other policy positions. Lake (2009) and Nieman (2016*b*) show that the position of a mi-

nor power within these networks impacts their domestic and foreign policies, with greater embeddedness associated with practices more in line with the major power.

I shift attention from cross-sectional to temporal variation in minor power positions within a political order over time. I examine how changes in a protégé’s relationship with a major power alter its domestic institutions and foreign-policy behavior. This temporal perspective matters because hierarchical ties are not fixed: states move in and out of favored status, bilateral relationships deepen or erode, and major-power orders expand, contract, and reconfigure.

My primary theoretical interest is major power *disengagement* and its consequences for protégés’ domestic institutions and foreign policy. I argue that disengagement has both short- and long-run effects for protégés’ policies. In the short-term, disengagement produces a reduction in material inducements and technical assistance. This, in turn, leads to an immediate shift in a protégé’s policy away from the major power’s preferred policies and milieu goals. Over the long-term, sustained reductions in major-power influence erode the patron’s capacity to encourage, reinforce, or pressure protégés toward its milieu goals through nonmaterial means. Without that steady pressure, protégés gravitate back toward their own ideal points and away from those of the patron—or even toward an alternative major power.

I expect reductions in major-power influence to move protégé behavior away from the patron’s milieu goals and geopolitical interests. When a liberal major power reduces support, protégés should exhibit both immediate and long-run declines in democratic and legal institutions, trade less with the patron, and move away from its preferred foreign-policy positions. These effects are likely amplified if the liberal major power’s influence is replaced by that of an illiberal power. Conversely, when an illiberal major power loses influence, we should observe movement in the opposite direction: a minor power adopting more liberal domestic reforms and pursuing a more independent foreign policy.

I evaluate these predictions using a Bayesian error correction model (ECM) (Nieman and Peterson 2026). This estimation strategy isolates temporal variation in major-power

influence and protégé behavior, while differencing out static, unobservable unit-level characteristics that may correlate with the outcome variable. The Bayesian framework, in turn, facilitates direct estimation of long-run effects and their uncertainty. The estimator allows for assessing both short- and long-run effects of changes in major-power influence on minor power domestic and foreign policy outcomes—including democratic reform, human rights and legal practices, international economic interactions, and foreign policy alignment—and thus provides a more complete picture of the total impact.

The results support the theoretical predictions across major powers and issue areas. Substantively, they underscore two core points. First, major power disengagement has systematic consequences for protégés’ domestic and foreign policy outcomes. Second, political orders differ considerably depending on their leaders’ milieu goals. Decreases in US influence, for example, are associated with short- and long-run declines in minor powers’ democratic practices, human rights protections, judicial independence, US trade, and US foreign policy alignment. In contrast, Russian reductions in support lead to minor powers’ liberal policy implementation and more independent foreign policies. I find analogous effects for other major powers: retrenchment by liberal powers—Britain and France—undermines the LIO, while diminished Chinese influence leads to greater policy independence.

More broadly, the analysis speaks to central debates in international relations. Examining the micro-effects of major power withdrawal, from a global sample of states across a wide range of policy areas, enables a more theoretically and empirically informed understanding of the macro-effects of the end of major power-led political orders. The implications extend beyond the fate of the LIO to questions of grand strategy, great-power competition, and the future of global order.

Building and Maintaining Political Orders

Recent scholarship on status and relational hierarchies views major powers as sitting atop networks of protégé states. These networks are inherently hierarchical, as the major power has significant policy influence over protégés (Lake 2009; McDonald 2015; Beardsley et al. 2020). Yet this influence is neither uniform nor absolute: protégés vary in their closeness to the major power and the extent of major-power influence over their policies (Wendt and Friedheim 1995; Nieman 2016*b*; Henke 2018, 2019*a,b*; Nedal and Nexon 2019). Thus, the strength of the bilateral hierarchical tie between a major power and each protégé is conceptualized along a continuum, rather than as a dichotomy of protégés and non-protégés.¹ A major power’s influence network is, therefore, theorized as a portfolio of bilateral relationships with a set of protégés. This conceptualization allows for overlapping protégé networks, whether because minor powers hedge or are cross-pressured, e.g., Turkey (Tessman 2012; Jackson 2014). An overlap in protégé portfolios may also result from aligned major powers (Nieman et al. 2021).

Each bilateral arrangement results from an explicit or implicit negotiation between a major power and its protégé regarding the degree of major-power influence (Lake 2009; Kang 2010; Ikenberry 2011). In the bargain, each actor pursues an outcome closer to its ideal point: major powers prioritize policy influence, while protégés seek security. The outcome depends on the two actors’ relative bargaining strength, which in turn reflects material and ideational factors. Protégés with strategic locations, valuable resources, or stronger outside options have a stronger bargaining position; protégés in more dangerous geopolitical environments or with fewer alternatives may have to concede more. Major powers with a more compelling ideology or a track record of material success can offer potential protégés fewer material benefits. Once negotiated, an arrangement enters an equilibrium, or maintenance, stage. Absent a change in ideal points, each party fulfills its side of the bargain from one period to

¹That is, I focus on the degree of connectivity (Hays, Kachi and Franzese 2010; Chyzh and Kaiser 2019) rather than separate communities (Beardsley et al. 2020; Wang et al. 2024).

the next.

These arrangements are mutually beneficial for major powers and their protégés (Morrow 1991; Lake 2009; Ikenberry 2011), while also shaping the cost-benefit calculations of other states within and across major power-led political orders (Nieman 2016*a,b*).² Protégés receive economic and security guarantees, and they benefit from the major power-led political order through lower defense spending, reduced trade costs, and access to the major power’s security and economic networks (Lake 2009; Allen, VanDusky-Allen and Flynn 2016; Allen, Flynn and VanDusky-Allen 2017; Allen 2018; Norrlof and Wohlforth 2019).³ At the micro-level, such benefits increase the resources available to leaders of protégé states and help them remain in power (Licht 2010; DiGiuseppe and Shea 2015, 2016; Lake 2024).

Major powers benefit both ideationally and materially from their protégé-networks. Ideationally, they gain a platform for promoting their milieu goals, diffusing their preferred norms and rules—domestic political, legal, and economic institutions—to their protégés (Fordham and Asal 2007; Ruby and Gibler 2010; Gunitsky 2014; Norrlof 2014; McDonald 2015; Chyzh and Labzina 2018; Martinez Machain 2021; Ryu et al. 2026). In the long term, this diffusion leads to shared preferences and foreign policy goals (Wolfers 1984; Lanoszka 2013; Mousseau 2019; Resnick 2022). As a result, major powers gain legitimacy for their actions when protégés join their international initiatives (Lake 2009; Henke 2017). Materially, major powers can integrate their economies and security networks with those of their protégés, and leverage their centrality within these networks to bolster their own power (Norrlof and Wohlforth 2019; Acevedo-Ossa 2025). Recent empirical work further illustrates these benefits: major powers shape the foreign policies of their protégés on military involvement (Nieman 2016*b*; Henke 2017, 2019*a,b*), alliance formation (Allen, Flynn and VanDusky-Allen 2017), and trade policy (Lake 2009; Fordham 2010; Allen 2018).

Such hierarchical relationships also carry costs. Protégés lose autonomy and are required

²See Chyzh (2016) for a formal assessment of how changing cost-benefit calculations impact network participation and domestic institutions.

³They also receive special treatment and are granted greater benefit-of-the-doubt should they break the rules than a non-protégé (Stone 2002, 2004; Nieman 2016*b*; Lipsy and Lee 2019; Ferry and Shea 2025).

to contribute to coalitions and organizations that support the major power-led political order (Nieman 2016*b*). Major powers, meanwhile, incur ‘governance costs’: maintaining a military capable of global power projection, providing military aid to protégés, sustaining a wide-ranging diplomatic presence, and defending protégés (Lake 2009; McManus and Nieman 2019).⁴ These costs limit the number of protégés a major power can retain or pursue (Gilpin 1981; MacDonald and Parent 2011; Haynes 2015). Even wealthy major powers cannot devote unlimited resources and attention to every actual or potential protégé, so they must prioritize among candidates for recruitment and retention.

Changes in Major-Power Influence

Major powers and protégés are both strategic actors, but their leverage is not symmetric. Protégés can bargain over whether a relationship forms and over its initial terms, but they do not control the patron’s subsequent level of commitment. After the initial bargain is reached, they can hedge, signal loyalty, diversify ties, or seek marginal adjustments, but these strategies cannot unilaterally increase the major power’s influence or prevent the major power from reducing it. A protégé seeking deeper ties may offer policy concessions, strategic access, or other benefits in an effort to alter the patron’s calculus. Greater support materializes, however, only when the major power concludes that a stronger commitment advances its own goals.

Protégés generally prefer continuity, subject to marginal adjustments in the terms of the relationship, because they benefit from major-power support—through security guarantees, resources, status, and external backing. Even when a protégé’s ideal point drifts away from the major power’s, such as after a change in the ruling societal coalition, the protégé is more likely to preserve the benefits of the relationship while seeking greater policy autonomy than to surrender those benefits voluntarily.⁵

⁴Musgrave and Nexon (2018) suggest that major powers may also undertake costly symbolic projects to demonstrate their capabilities and legitimacy.

⁵Even when a protégé hedges between two rival major powers, as Turkey has between Russia and the

Major powers, by contrast, control the supply of support. If a major power seeks greater influence, it can offer additional resources, diplomatic backing, or other inducements that make closer alignment more attractive. If the major power seeks to reduce its commitment, it can withdraw unilaterally, without obtaining the protégé’s consent. Changes in the depth of the relationship therefore ultimately depend on the major power’s willingness to incur the costs of sustaining or increasing its influence.

Major powers may revise the relationship for two reasons. One is domestic political change within the major power itself: a change in the ruling societal coalition may lead to a foreign policy reorientation or an emphasis on different milieu goals (Cantir and Kaarbo 2012; Wehner and Thies 2014; Mattes, Leeds and Carroll 2015; Demirduzen and Thies 2022; Nedal and Schramm 2025; Wehner 2025). The other is the broader geopolitical environment: shifts in material power (Bell and Johnson 2015), an unexpected move by a rival (Nieman et al. 2021), or a major shock like the September 11 attacks can lead a major power to reassess its priorities and reallocate support across its protégés. Such shifts alter the relative costs and benefits of maintaining influence over a given protégé (Gilpin 1981; Palmer and Morgan 2006; Braumoeller 2008, 2012; Martinez Machain and Morgan 2013).

Whether a major power deepens, maintains, or reduces a relationship depends primarily on the protégé’s value to its broader geopolitical objectives, including its strategic location, resources, and role in competition with rival powers. A protégé’s domestic politics (e.g., ideology, democracy) are typically secondary. While relationships with protégés whose domestic policies are aligned with those of the major power are, all else equal, less costly to maintain, domestic alignment alone rarely gives the protégé the capacity to induce a major-power commitment. For example, both Ukraine and Georgia have long sought closer ties with the US, the UK, and France through pro-democracy reform, yet neither country’s democratic credentials alone secured the level of Western commitment it sought. Ukraine attracted little sustained interest from these Western powers until it demonstrated an ability to withstand

United States, it generally seeks to preserve access to benefits from both relationships.

Russian military aggression, which raised its strategic value for European security. Georgia, meanwhile, has failed to gain comparable commitments despite pursuing a similar reform agenda.

Likewise, while spreading democracy was one of the US's central goals after the Cold War, democratization has not been a condition of continued US support. The US has maintained close relations with many non-democratic regimes that serve its strategic interests, including Gulf monarchies and authoritarian anti-communist governments during the Cold War. Consistent with this logic, the US has rarely tried to democratize a country before bringing it into its orbit, nor has it devoted large-scale resources to promote democracy among non-aligned states. Domestic compatibility can facilitate influence once a strategic relationship exists, but the major power's geopolitical objectives determine whether it is willing to establish, deepen, or sustain that relationship in the first place.

All else equal, major powers prefer that their protégé domestic policies and institutions resemble their own, because compatibility lowers the costs of sustaining influence. Domestic institutional alignment, however, is neither necessary for entry into a major power's order nor sufficient by itself to induce or terminate a commitment. This asymmetry makes changes in major-power influence plausibly exogenous to contemporaneous protégé's policy choices.

Major-Power Disengagement

Substantial disengagement by a major power, of course, is relatively rare. Once a major power formulates its geopolitical interests and sets up its portfolio of protégé relationships, there is likely to be a long period of normalcy before a large change takes place. During these periods of normalcy, there still may be small adjustments to individual relationships within the portfolio—for example, changing political administrations may emphasize relationships with particular protégés more than others. From the perspective of most protégés, therefore, this period may be characterized by little change. A small number of protégés, meanwhile, may experience greater fluctuation in their relationship with the patron.

Disengagement also varies in scale. During periods of domestic contestation or geopolitical turmoil, a major power may pull back from several protégés at once, and if the turmoil is severe enough, it may abandon its own order altogether (Hyde and Saunders 2025; Kang and Gibler 2013, 699). The Soviet collapse is a clear case: maintaining authority over satellite states became a lower priority than managing pressing domestic crises.

Disengagement can also happen more gradually, through strategic retrenchment, in which a major power scales back its overall footprint while still preserving influence in key regions (MacDonald and Parent 2011). Britain’s decline after World War II, France’s withdrawal from Southeast Asia in the 1950s, and France’s more recent pullback from parts of francophone Africa are all examples. Even within a region, retrenchment rarely proceeds evenly; it varies substantially in both speed and scope (Haynes 2015).

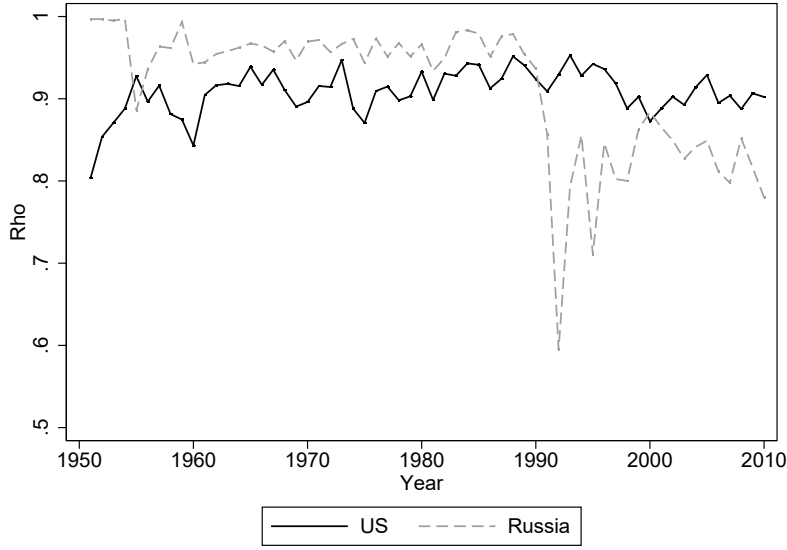
Observationally, disengagement may appear as troop drawdowns, alliance termination, reductions in military assistance, canceled military exercises or high-level visits, or public statements that weaken prior commitments. These signals need not all move together, nor must they always culminate in a formal break. A major power may instead reduce support along some dimensions while maintaining others, resulting in partial or uneven disengagement. Recent US debates over troop levels in Europe illustrate this dynamic: even when formal alliance commitments remain in place, threats to reduce deployments or uncertainty about future support can signal a weakening of patron commitment.

Such observable indicators may inform us of the stability or change in major power relationships with their protégés. McManus and Nieman (2019) combined these indicators into a single dyadic latent measure of major power support for protégés using a Bayesian measurement model.⁶ These data can illustrate the seeming stability within a major power order for most protégés while also uncovering fluctuation for a smaller segment.

Figure 1 plots year-to-year correlations in dyadic major power–protégé influence measured using McManus and Nieman’s (2019) latent score. For example, the US estimate for 1951

⁶The measure is described in detail, along with its seven component indicators and their construction, in the Research Design section.

Figure 1: Year-to-Year Correlation of Dyadic Major Power–Protégé Influence.



is calculated from US–protégé dyads observed in 1951 and the corresponding level of US support in those same dyads in 1950; the Russian estimates are constructed analogously. The US correlation stays consistently high, ranging from $\rho = .8$ to $\rho = .95$. Russia’s starts out even higher, around $\rho = .95$ and peaking at $\rho = .99$, but drops sharply to $\rho = .59$ during the Soviet collapse before climbing back to roughly $\rho = .83$ by the 2000s.

These high year-to-year correlations, however, mask longer-run trends. Table 1 reports, on the left, the correlation between the dyadic level of major-power influence and its one- and five-year lags. For both the US and Russia, the one-year correlation is high at $\rho = .91$. Five years out, it drops to $\rho = .85$ for the US and $\rho = .82$ for Russia—a modest but real decline.

The right-hand side of Table 1 tells a complementary story, reporting the correlation between the year-to-year *change* in influence and its own one- and five-year lags. Here the one-year correlation is moderately negative, which points to some reversion the year right after a rise or fall in influence. At five years, that correlation disappears entirely.

Together, these patterns indicate high persistence in dyadic levels of influence and short-run mean reversion in annual changes. Changes are therefore generally followed by relative

Table 1: Correlation in Dyadic Major Power–Protégé Influence

	<u>Level of Influence</u>		<u>Change in Influence</u>	
	One Year Lag	Five Year Lag	One Year Lag	Five Year Lag
US	.91	.85	-.38	-.01
Russia	.91	.82	-.30	-.06

stability. In other words, major-power influence is generally stable once established, and quickly reaches a new steady state after a shift.⁷

Major-power disengagement is not just a symptom of decline—it can happen even as a major power grows stronger. Retrenchment in one area can accompany expansion or steady commitment elsewhere, as part of a broader reshuffling of foreign-policy priorities. The US’s repeated “pivot to Asia,” for instance, has meant shifting resources toward the Indo-Pacific at the expense of Latin America and Western Europe. Geopolitical shocks can trigger the same kind of reshuffling: after the September 11 attacks, the US ramped up engagement with Middle Eastern and African governments to fight terrorism, reversing course on its prior retrenchment from the Middle East and its general disengagement from Africa. Major powers, in other words, can disengage from some allies even while cultivating relationships and expanding influence elsewhere.

Political Orders and Protégé Behavior

Major power-led political orders differ in the domestic institutions, economic practices, and foreign-policy commitments they encourage among protégés (Simmons and Elkins 2004; Fordham and Asal 2007; Gunitsky 2014; McDonald 2015). These differences reflect the major power’s milieu goals (Wolfers 1984; Mousseau 2019), but they also serve a functional purpose within hierarchy. Protégés that resemble the patron are cheaper to manage. Shared legal and regulatory institutions lower the costs of trade, investment, and dispute resolution;

⁷This pattern is consistent with the conditional-equilibrium logic underlying the empirical strategy. Small changes in support may occur as part of routine bargaining within an existing relationship and should produce correspondingly small shifts in the protégé’s conditional equilibrium. Large reductions in support, by contrast, represent patron-driven disruptions to the prior status quo and should produce more substantively meaningful short- and long-run adjustments.

compatible administrative practices make technical assistance and policy coordination easier; military interoperability facilitates coalition warfare; and foreign-policy alignment reduces the diplomatic costs of securing support in international organizations and crises (Leeds 1999; Lai and Reiter 2000; Mousseau 2003; Mitchell and Powell 2011; Liu 2014; Cook and Liu 2016; Ward 2020). What appear as benefits to protégés are therefore also instruments of order maintenance (Wendt and Friedheim 1995; Lanoszka 2013; Chyzh and Labzina 2018). By encouraging protégés to adopt its preferred institutions and practices, a major power reduces the costs of sustaining influence over them.

As part of the LIO, the US has promoted democratic institutions, legalism, and market-oriented governance because they reflect liberal preferences, but also because they make US leadership easier to sustain. Legal and market institutions, for example, facilitate exchange on terms familiar to US firms and policymakers. These further embed US material and ideological interests in rules that coordinate behavior across the order (Keohane 1984; Ikenberry 2000, 2011).

Alternative major power-led orders promote different institutional forms, but the same structural incentives remain. China, for example, offers a developmental model that combines economic assistance with fewer demands for domestic reform, while also providing tools for managing domestic opposition (Carmody and Owusu 2007; Greitens and Kardon 2024; Ikenberry 2024). This approach supports aligned governments and expands China’s economic and political reach (An and Wang 2024), while also extending the reach of its gray-zone activities, such as economic pressure, misinformation, cyber-attacks, and harassment of political opponents (Belo 2022, 279). The content of the order differs, but the purpose is comparable: major powers promote institutions and practices that make protégés more predictable, more cooperative, and less costly to keep within their order. Milieu goals therefore often involve the adoption by protégés of the major power’s preferred domestic institutions and practices.⁸

⁸Contradictions between the promoted ideology and its practice often exist (e.g., Pickering and Peceny 2006; Freeman 2023; Rathbun, Parker and Pomeroy 2025).

Major powers rarely dictate protégé policy directly. They exercise influence indirectly, by supporting domestic groups whose interests align, or can be made to align, with the patron’s preferred policies (Lake 2024). These groups translate external support into domestic policy: they defend the patron’s preferred foreign-policy positions, maintain institutional arrangements compatible with the patron’s milieu goals, and use the benefits of external backing to strengthen their domestic position. The resulting policy “type” can be sticky, because it is embedded in the preferences and survival strategies of domestic coalitions rather than imposed anew by the patron in each period.

This institutionalization of influence makes disengagement consequential. Major-power support does not merely purchase discrete policy concessions; it sustains the domestic coalitions, administrative practices, security relationships, and elite networks through which the patron’s preferred order is reproduced. As support declines, these foundations of alignment weaken.

Major-power disengagement operates through three linked mechanisms: the weakening of patron-aligned domestic coalitions, the reduction of material and technical support, and the erosion of ideational channels that transmit the patron’s preferences. These mechanisms differ in timing. Coalition and material channels can generate short-term policy movement because they affect the domestic actors and state capacities through which major-power influence is exercised. Ideational channels operate more slowly, as the interactions that reproduce alignment decay over time. The effect of withdrawal should therefore vary with the size and duration of the reduction in major-power influence.

Patron-aligned coalitions depend not only on the fact of major-power support, but on its expected continuity. External backing supplies resources, credibility, security assistance, diplomatic recognition, and access to the patron’s wider network. As support declines, the coalition’s domestic position weakens proportionally. It may lose legislative seats, become more dependent on coalition partners, face stronger opposition from rival factions, or find it harder to justify policies associated with the patron. A modest reduction in support

may require limited concessions while leaving the coalition’s basic policy orientation intact. A larger reduction should produce greater pressure: opposition groups become more viable, coalition partners demand more policy compromise, and incumbents have stronger incentives to recalibrate under a diminished support environment. If the reduction persists, these pressures accumulate, eroding the material, coercive, diplomatic, and reputational foundations that sustain patron-aligned policy (Lake 2024).

Material inducements and technical assistance reinforce this coalition mechanism. Major powers use aid, arms transfers, military cooperation, bureaucratic training, and other forms of capacity-building to secure compliance, maintain access, and help protégés implement preferred policies (Powers 2004; Palmer and Morgan 2006; Carter and Stone 2015; Henke 2017, 2019*b*). These instruments do not simply reward alignment after the fact; they help produce the administrative, military, and political capacity through which alignment is sustained. Technical assistance, in particular, is an accumulated investment that requires continued maintenance. Reductions in assistance may remove the training, oversight, funding, or security cooperation needed to keep that capacity functioning. Close ties to the US, for example, can strengthen state capacity and reduce the risk of civil war onset (DiGiuseppe and Shea 2022; see also Kalyvas and Balcells 2010), while US military training of foreign officers has been linked to improvements in civilian control and human rights practices (Ruby and Gibler 2010; Martinez Machain 2021). When those channels weaken, the domestic and institutional foundations of the patron’s preferred policies weaken as well.

H₁: Reduction of major-power influence leads to a short-term shift away from that major power’s milieu goals and foreign policy positions by the protégé.

Ideational channels operate more slowly because they work by reproducing the patron’s preferences among protégé elites, bureaucracies, and publics. Major powers transmit these preferences through education, training, diplomatic contact, aid programs, media, and repeated participation in patron-centered institutions. International student flows, foreign military or professional training shape domestic preferences over time (Spilimbergo 2009;

Atkinson 2010; Weymouth and MacPherson 2012; Ruby and Gibler 2010; Martinez Machain 2021; Gift and Krcmaric 2017; Nieman and Allamong 2023; Stanko 2024). Similar processes operate through direct contact with foreign representatives, humanitarian and financial assistance programs, media influence, and learning from perceived success (Allen et al. 2020, 2023; Truckos 2021; Blair, Marty and Roessler 2022; An and Wang 2024; Jenks 2006; Brady 2015; Mader, Marinov and Schoen 2022; Simmons and Elkins 2004; Simmons, Dobbin and Garrett 2006). These channels do not simply transmit information. They shape which policies elites view as feasible, legitimate, and desirable.

Their influence, however, depends on sustained engagement. When support declines, the patron’s ability to reinforce its preferred norms and practices weakens. Elite networks thin, training and exchange programs lose salience, bureaucratic routines become less tied to the patron, and domestic actors have greater room to reinterpret or abandon policies associated with the former order. This erosion need not produce an immediate break. Instead, it should generate gradual drift away from the patron’s milieu goals as the protégé’s own preferences, or those of alternative partners, become more consequential.⁹

The Sino-Soviet split illustrates this process. During the late stages of the Korean War, Soviet military assistance to China slowed (Lüthi 2008, 36). That material retrenchment coincided with ideological divergence following Khrushchev’s de-Stalinization program (Lin 2024, 104–107), weakening the channels that had linked Beijing to Moscow’s political order. By 1959, China had adjusted its trade policy, suspending supply contracts with Moscow and expanding trade with Japan and Western Europe (Lüthi 2008, 174–177), despite continuing to hold anti-capitalist and anti-US preferences (Beylerian and Canivet 1997; Thies and Nieman 2017, 118–127). The case shows why long-run divergence need not require immediate conversion to a rival order. A protégé can move away from the patron’s preferred policies as the material and ideational channels sustaining alignment erode.

⁹Coercive efforts to alter a state’s ideational trajectory, such as foreign-imposed regime change (Lo, Hashimoto and Reiter 2008) and election interference (Levin 2016, 2020) often lack sustained engagement and have destabilizing or countervailing long-term impacts (Downes and O’Rourke 2016; Chyzh and Labzina 2018; Yetim 2023, 2025).

Over the long run, sustained disengagement should therefore move the protégé toward a new conditional equilibrium away from the patron’s preferred policies and institutions.

H₂: A sustained reduction in major-power influence results in a protégé’s long-term divergence from that major power’s milieu goals and foreign policy positions, with the degree of divergence increasing in the size and duration of the reduction.

Disengagement from one major power does not imply immediate incorporation into an alternative political order. Influence lost by one patron is not automatically gained by a rival. Many protégés remain non-aligned after losing support; others enter alternative patronage relationships only gradually. Using the McManus and Nieman (2019) data, the correlation between *US Influence* and *Russia Influence* for protégés from 1950–2010 is only $r = -.07$, indicating that decreases in one form of influence are not mechanically matched by increases in the other.¹⁰

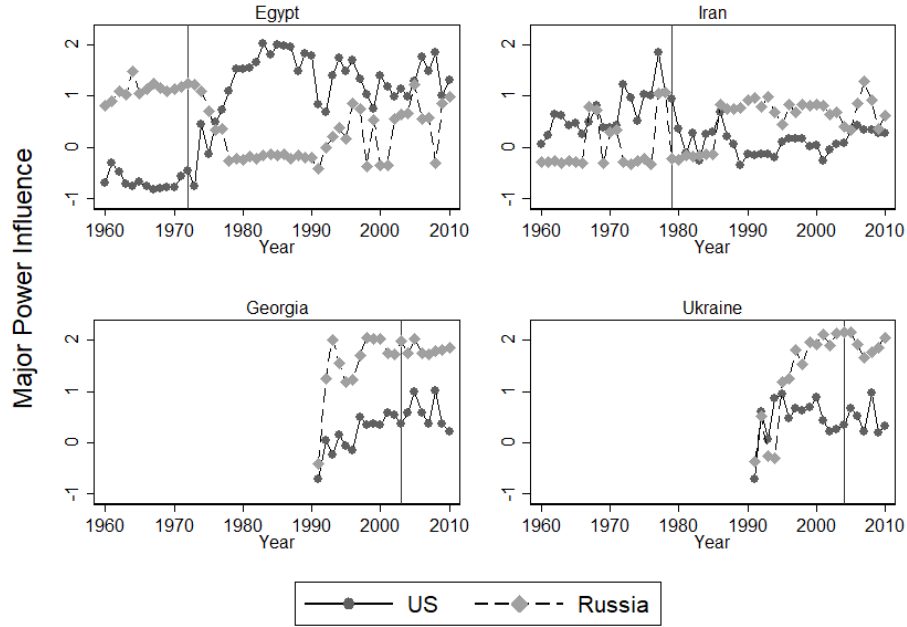
Historical cases illustrate this gradualism. As shown in Figure 2, al-Sadat’s Egypt after severing the Soviet alliance in 1972, Iran after its 1979 Islamic Revolution, Georgia after the 2003 Rose Revolution, and Ukraine after the 2004 Orange Revolution did not move instantaneously from one major-power order to another. Egypt shifted from Soviet to US influence over several years; Iran moved toward the Soviet order over a half-decade; Russia continued to exert influence in Georgia and Ukraine after the Color Revolutions, with only modest increases in US influence. These cases suggest that losing one patron usually produces non-alignment or gradual realignment rather than immediate substitution.¹¹

When alternative patronage does emerge, however, it should amplify long-run policy change. A protégé that loses support from one major power and later gains support from

¹⁰If the US- and Russia-led political orders were reverse images, the correlation would be strongly negative, rather than close to zero.

¹¹Even in cases such as the Cuban Revolution—where the fall of the Batista regime and rise of Castro coincided with a transition from the US political order to the Soviet one—the shifts were not simultaneous (Stodden and Weiss 2016). Castro initially retained several moderate and liberal officials, emphasized the need for continued positive economic relations with the US, and described both the USSR and the US as equally imperialist. His relations with the Soviets remained cold through much of 1959. Only after the Soviet Technical and Agricultural Exposition was moved to Havana did Cuba fully shift into the Soviet network (Stodden and Weiss 2016, 82–87).

Figure 2: US and Russian Influence in Egypt, Iran, Georgia, and Ukraine.



Note: The vertical line indicates the timing of a major policy change. From top left to bottom right: al-Sadat’s withdrawal from the Soviet alliance, Iranian Revolution, Georgia’s Rose Revolution, and Ukraine’s Orange Revolution.

another is exposed to two forces at once: the erosion of the former patron’s influence and the growing pressure, inducements, and socialization associated with the new patron. The resulting policy shift should be greater than disengagement alone because the protégé is not merely moving away from one political order—it is increasingly being pulled toward another.

H₃: Increases in alternative major-power influence should move protégé outcomes toward the new patron’s milieu goals and foreign-policy positions, even after controlling for the influence from the original patron.

Research Design

I evaluate these hypotheses using annual data on major-power influence for all minor powers from 1950–2010. Specifically, I use data from McManus and Nieman (2019) that capture security relationships between major and minor powers. Major powers are defined as the

US, Russia, China, UK, and France, with all other states treated as minor powers.

I examine how changes in major-power influence over a protégé correspond to changes across a range of that minor power’s domestic and foreign policies: democratic reform, human rights protections, judicial independence, trade openness, bilateral trade share with the major power, and foreign policy alignment. For domestic institutions and policies, I expect changes in major-power influence to align with shifts in the protégé toward the patron’s milieu goals, e.g., toward liberalism for the US, UK, and France, and toward illiberalism for Russia and China (Wolfers 1984; McDonald 2015; Martinez Machain 2021; Nieman and Allamong 2023).

Methodology

I use a Bayesian ECM to evaluate the hypotheses. An ECM allows me to focus on the dynamic properties of the relationship between changes in major-power influence and minor power’s policy outcomes (De Boef and Keele 2008; Webb, Linn and Lebo 2020). A Bayesian framework, meanwhile, aids in the construction of estimates of the long-run effects, particularly their associated uncertainty (Nieman and Peterson 2026).

The ECM is specified as:

$$\Delta y_t = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 y_{t-1} + \beta_0 \Delta x_t + \beta_1 x_{t-1} + \epsilon_t, \quad (1)$$

where the first difference of y_t is determined by a constant, α_0 , the lagged value of y_{t-1} , the first difference and lagged value of x_t , and the stochastic term, ϵ_t .¹² The error correction parameter, α_1 , accounts for how fast the system (i.e., the time series of y and x) reaches the new (conditional) equilibrium after a shock. The theoretical range of this parameter is $-2 < \alpha_1 < 0$, where the midpoint, $\alpha = -1$, implies an immediate return to equilibrium, whereas values further away (toward either bound) imply a slower return.¹³

¹²For simplicity, I suppress the unit subscript and the vectors of first-differenced and lagged control variables.

¹³An error correction rate where $-1 < \alpha_1 < 0$ implies a steady return to the long-run equilibrium, whereas a rate of $-2 < \alpha_1 < -1$ indicates an oscillating return. Values of either $\alpha_1 > 0$ or $\alpha_1 < -2$ mean that the relationship is explosive and no long-run equilibrium exists. See Keele, Linn and Webb (2016, 302–303).

The instantaneous effect of a change in x_t is captured by β_0 , while the coefficient β_1 captures the persistent component of this effect. The latter identifies the effect of a change from the initial (conditional) equilibrium that will then reverberate through the lagged dependent variable until the system reaches the new (conditional) equilibrium. The long-run effect of a change in x on y , then, accounts for the cumulative adjustment to a sustained change in x . This is calculated from the long-run multiplier (LRM), which is the persistent component divided by the error correction rate, or $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$.

While recovering an estimate of the long-run effect is relatively straightforward, calculating its uncertainty is more complicated, as there is not a direct estimate of the standard error of the LRM (De Boef and Keele 2008, 191–192). Since the LRM is a ratio of coefficients, the formula for the variance of the ratio of coefficients with known variances can be used. The formula is:

$$Var\left(\frac{a}{b}\right) = \left(\frac{1}{b^2}\right)Var(a) + \left(\frac{a^2}{b^4}\right)Var(b) - 2\left(\frac{a}{b^3}\right)Cov(a, b). \quad (2)$$

There are two common approaches to approximate the variance of this ratio. The first is to calculate the LRM from an ECM and use the Bewley transformation. The second approach is to apply the Delta method, which expands a random variable—in this case the LRM—via a Taylor series. While these estimates of the standard error are *asymptotically* accurate, they may not be as appropriate for relatively short series, or when the dynamic properties of the data exhibit high autocorrelation or are unknown (Webb, Linn and Lebo 2019, 2020; Nieman and Peterson 2026). The data used in the current study exhibit both characteristics: a short time series and a high autocorrelation for the key variables. As a result, the approximations of the variance of the LRM can lead to standard errors that do not conform with the theoretical range of the point estimates, and possibly take on nonsensical values (Nieman and Peterson 2026).¹⁴

¹⁴If the confidence interval for α_1 nears or exceeds 0, then the denominator of the LRM can take on values arbitrarily close to zero or, if the interval crosses zero, values of the opposite sign. In that case, the estimation of the variance of the LRM will be “mildly explosive” Hill and Peng (2014, 293). If $\alpha_1 = 0$, the

I overcome these issues by applying a Bayesian technique developed by Nieman and Peterson (2026) that directly estimates the LRM and its uncertainty. The technique uses a semi-informed prior on the coefficient of the lagged dependent variable and estimates the posterior distribution from Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) simulations. The semi-informed prior is specified as a uniform distribution between -2 and 0. This prior constrains the variance of the dynamic relationship to its theoretical bounds, but gives equal weight to values between these bounds so as not to determine the point estimate.

Estimation via MCMC takes advantage of the well-known property that functions of parameters (e.g., ratios of coefficients) can be estimated and summarized *directly* from the posterior distribution (Gelfand et al. 1990; Murr, Traunmüller and Gill 2023). This avoids the need for asymptotic assumptions: once a Markov chain has converged, each individual MCMC simulation draws parameter estimates from the joint probability distribution and, since the LRM is a ratio of coefficients, the LRM can also be drawn from the posterior distribution.¹⁵ The combination of the semi-informed prior and MCMC estimation provides direct and theoretically-informed estimates of the long-run effects of a change in the independent variable.

The Bayesian ECM is specified as in Eq 1, with a semi-informed prior of $\mathcal{U}(-2, 0)$ on the coefficient for lagged y , diffuse priors of $\mathcal{N}(0, 20)$ for the constant and the coefficients associated with Δx_t and x_{t-1} , and a prior for the variance distributed $\mathcal{G}(1, 10)$. The specific size of the MCMC sample, number of burn-in iterations, and degree of thinning vary based on diagnostics for the specific model.

The ECM parameterization matches the theoretical language of change and adjustment. Changes in major-power influence should affect protégé behavior immediately and continue to matter as the protégé adjusts to its new support environment. The ECM specification makes these two quantities explicit: the coefficient on the change in major-power influence

variance will be undefined.

¹⁵The quality of inference for sampling-based methods, such as MCMCs, relies on the *number of samples* taken, rather than the *size of the sample* (McNeish 2016).

estimates the short-term effect, while the lagged terms allow calculation of the LRM, or the cumulative adjustment to a sustained change in influence (De Boef and Keele 2008; Webb, Linn and Lebo 2020).¹⁶

The ECM is also appropriate because the variables analyzed here are highly persistent; parameterizing the key variables in terms of change reduces the risk of a spurious finding induced by autocorrelation (De Boef and Keele 2008, 195). Under these conditions, an ECM is the standard specification for modeling short-run change and long-run adjustment to a new conditional equilibrium (De Boef and Keele 2008; Keele, Linn and Webb 2016; Linn, Lebo and Webb 2026).

Major-power Influence

In order to capture the degree of *major-power influence* directed toward a minor power, I use the data from McManus and Nieman (2019). These scores are measured annually for each minor power, from each major power, for the period from 1950 to 2010. The data are derived from a Bayesian latent measurement model to estimate the level of major power support based on seven indicators: alliances, nuclear and troop deployments, arms transfers, military exercises, and leadership visits and statements.¹⁷ The measurement model captures the latent level of influence by estimating the relative importance of the individual signals based on their frequency and correlation, and calculates the total support for each minor power based on the relative weights of the observed signals they receive.

These indicators are valuable in measuring major-power influence, as they reflect reciprocal ties or costly signals of commitment. Alliances, exercises, deployments, visits, and arms transfers require more than just intention on the part of the major power but also a degree of agreement and subordination on the part of the recipient protégé, reflecting the

¹⁶A temporary change followed by a reversal would be modeled as a sequence of changes in the support environment: the initial decline moves the outcome away from the prior conditional equilibrium, while the subsequent increase may offset some or all of that adjustment.

¹⁷The indicator data on alliances are from Gibler (2009), nuclear deployments from (Fuhrmann and Sechser 2014), troop deployments from Braithwaite (2015), arms transfers from SIPRI (2018), military exercises from D’Orazio (2016), and leadership visits and statements from McManus (2018).

security–autonomy tradeoff (Morrow 1991; Lake 2009; Johnson 2015). Moreover, because these signals can be reduced, suspended, or allowed to lapse across different dimensions of the relationship, they are well suited for examining partial as well as substantial major-power disengagement.¹⁸

The *major-power influence* measure offers other advantages over alternative measures. First, rather than relying on just one or two indicators, the latent measure accounts for a variety of potential foreign policy tools at a major power’s disposal, while weighing each indicator’s relative contribution. Next, by incorporating several indicators, the measure can account for foreign policy substitution among foreign policy tools (Most and Starr 1989; Palmer and Morgan 2006; Yarhi-Milo, Lanoszka and Cooper 2016). This is important, as some major powers use different indicators for democratic and autocratic protégés (McManus and Yarhi-Milo 2017). Finally, rather than assuming that all indicators convey the same informational value when used by different major powers, McManus and Nieman (2019) account for heterogeneity in the strength of individual gestures across major powers.

Dependent Variables

I evaluate the hypotheses using several dependent variables. This strategy allows me to assess whether the impact of changes in major-power influence is consistent across a range of domestic and foreign policy outcomes.

Democracy is operationalized using the polyarchy score from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project (Pemstein and von Römer 2025). The polyarchy measure is an index that weighs various indicators of electoral processes and government constraints. The resulting measure ranges from 0 to 1.

I also explore other domestic legal institutions, specifically *human rights protections* and

¹⁸In the Online Appendix, I perform robustness checks in which *major power disengagement* is measured as a binary variable: 1 for a large decrease and 0 otherwise. I set the threshold to approximate the size of terminating an alliance by a major power (see McManus and Nieman 2019, Table 1); a decrease of this size could reflect the termination of a single signal of support or the cumulative effect of reductions across several dimensions. The results presented below are robust to this alternative measure.

judicial independence. Human rights protections capture the level of physical integrity rights protections using data from Fariss (2014). Fariss uses a measurement model to estimate latent human rights protections over time while accounting for changing standards of accountability. The data range between -3.11 and 4.67. Judicial independence is a latent variable of de facto independence in the rule of law based on a measurement model developed by Linzer and Staton (2015). This measure also ranges from 0 to 1.

Next, I account for *trade openness* and *major power share of trade* to capture international economic policy. Trade openness captures how dependent an economy is on international economic processes and is measured as a state's total trade divided by GDP. Major power trade share captures the share of a country's total trade conducted with the specified major power. These are measured using trade data from Barbieri, Keshk and Pollins (2009) and GDP from Gleditsch (2002).

Finally, *foreign policy alignment* is operationalized in two ways. First, I use an alliance-based measure of foreign policy similarity. The assumption is that states with less diversified alliance portfolios, such as those where most or all allies share an alliance with the same major power, are more reliant on that major power and more aligned in their foreign policy. Conversely, a more diversified alliance portfolio, with a greater share of alliances that are independent of the major power, is less aligned (Bueno de Mesquita 1981; Lake 2009). The specific variable employed is Häge's (2011) kappa measure.

Second, I use a measure based on UN General Assembly voting agreement. While alliances capture broad, structural dimensions of foreign policy alignment, UN voting accounts for more issue-specific and flexible aspects. I operationalize this measure as the percentage agreement with a specific major power and obtain UN voting data from Bailey, Strezhnev and Voeten (2017). Together, these two measures capture the most common dimensions of foreign policy similarity (Signorino and Ritter 1999; Gallop and Minhas 2021).

Controls

I also include several statistical controls. I include *GDP/capita* and *external threat* in all models. GDP/capita is from Gleditsch (2002). External threat is a continuous latent measure that captures the probability of a violent militarized dispute given a state’s geopolitical neighborhood and is obtained from Nieman and Gibler (2023). Models for human rights protections include controls for the logged number of *protests*, logged *population*, and an indicator for a new or ongoing *civil war*. The first two variables are from Banks and Wilson (2010) and the last variable from Dixon and Sarkees (2016). Models for trade openness, major power trade share, and foreign policy alignment include controls for GDP. The trade models also account for human rights protections. Lastly, all models include democracy (except when it is the outcome of interest).

Since the ECM focuses on the first difference of the dependent variables, rather than their levels, time-invariant cross-sectional factors (e.g., former colonial status) or unit-level unobservables, which are often modeled with dummy variables or country fixed effects, are effectively differenced out of the estimated equations.

Results

I evaluate the hypotheses across several domestic and foreign policy domains. The results are presented in two parts: the top of each table reports the short-term effects of changes in major-power influence, while the bottom of each table displays the long-term effects. For each, I summarize the posterior distribution from the MCMCs by reporting the median value as a point estimate and its 95 percent credible interval in braces.

Democratic institutions. Table 2 reports the impact of changes in US and Russian influence on a protégé’s level of democracy. Model 1 focuses on the impact of changes in US influence. The coefficient on $\Delta US\ Influence$ is the instantaneous effect, which is positive, and its 95 percent credible interval excludes zero. In fact, the effect is positive in over 99.9% of

Table 2: Effect of Changes in Major-power Influence on Protégé Democracy.

Sample:	All Regimes	Mixed Regimes	Mixed Regimes
Δ US Influence	.005 [.002, .008]	.008 [.003, .012]	.008 [.003, .012]
US Influence $_{t-1}$	.004 [.002, .005]	.008 [.005, .010]	.007 [.005, .010]
Δ Russia Influence			-.005 [-.011, .001]
Russia Influence $_{t-1}$			-.003 [-.005, -.001]
Democracy $_{t-1}$	-.017 [-.021, -.012]	-.075 [-.086, -.065]	-.080 [-.089, -.069]
Long-run Effect			
US Influence	.215 [.122, .315]	.102 [.068, .138]	.090 [.058, .124]
Russia Influence			-.042 [-.069, -.016]
Controls	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	7945	4154	4154

Note: Median and 95% credible interval (in braces) summarize the posterior distribution estimated from a Bayesian error correction model with 50,000 retained posterior draws following 250,000 burn-in iterations and thinning every 50th draw. Control variables are *GDP/capita* and *external threat*. Long-run effects are constructed from the MCMCs as the negative ratio of the coefficient on lagged influence to the coefficient on the lagged dependent variable (long-run multiplier: $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$).

the draws from the posterior, indicating an extremely high level of confidence. This implies that the level of democracy increases in response to year-to-year increase in US influence. The inverse, then, also holds: a decrease in US influence leads to a decrease in a protégé's democracy level. This offers initial support for Hypothesis 1.

The long-term impact of changes in US influence is constructed from the ratio of the coefficients on *US Influence $_{t-1}$* and *Democracy $_{t-1}$* . The former represents the persistent component of a change in major-power influence, while the latter captures the error correction rate, that is, the speed in which the system settles at the new (conditional) equilibrium. This ratio is the LRM, which represents the total effect of a change in the independent variable.

The coefficient on *US Influence $_{t-1}$* is positive, and so is its 95 percent credible interval; here, more than 99.9% of draws from the posterior are positive. The coefficient for *Democracy $_{t-1}$* is very close to zero—the upper limit—with $\alpha_1 = -.017$, which indicates a very slow return to equilibrium. In other words, the variable is largely determined by its own

prior values and exhibits a high degree of autocorrelation.¹⁹ As such, a shock in influence at time t will impact future values of the outcome for periods far beyond the initial change.

As noted above, an advantage of the Bayesian approach in the context of an ECM is its estimation of the long-run effects and their variance. These quantities are obtained directly from the MCMC draws (Gelfand et al. 1990; Murr, Traunmüller and Gill 2023). There is clear evidence that a change in US influence has a positive long-run impact on a protégé’s level of democracy: the median estimate is a .215 increase in the level of democracy and the entirety of the 95 percent credible interval is above zero, with a lower bound of .122 and an upper bound of .315, and over 99.9% of draws above zero. A decrease in US influence, of course, would translate to the inverse of these figures. Substantively, this is a shift in the quality of democracy equivalent to the difference between the single party rule Mexico of 1992 and its competitive democratic 2008 version.

The slight asymmetry in the Bayesian credible intervals reflects the slow error correction rate: as the denominator (α_1) of the long-run multiplier nears zero, the impact of the numerator (β_1) is significantly heightened and skews the credible interval. This asymmetry highlights the value of the Bayesian ECM with a semi-informed prior on the coefficient on the dependent variable when there is a high degree of autocorrelation and the time series is short—the maximum length of a time series for any country in the sample is 61 observations.

Model 2 repeats the analysis, but restricts the sample to mixed regimes only.²⁰ The results are similar: the coefficients for $\Delta US Influence$ and $US Influence_{t-1}$ are positive, while the parameter on $Democracy_{t-1}$ is slightly lower at $\alpha_1 = -.075$ but still indicates that contemporaneous shocks persist through strong temporal autocorrelation. Though the short-run effect sizes of a change in US influence and the previous level of influence are slightly greater than in the full sample, the reduction in the size of the error correction rate is large

¹⁹An estimate of $\alpha_1 = -.017$ from the ECM in equation 1 is equivalent to $\alpha'_1 = .983$ from an ADL model where $y_t = \alpha'_0 + \beta'_0 x_t + \beta'_1 x_{t-1} + \alpha'_1 y_{t-1} + \epsilon_t$: the two estimators are mathematically equivalent (Marriott and Newbold 1998, 327–328; De Bouf and Keele 2008, 189–190; Keele, Linn, and Webb 2016).

²⁰States are coded as mixed regimes if their value on V-Dem’s polyarchy measure ranges between .15 and .65. This range excludes consolidated democracies and autocracies.

enough to reduce the long-run effect roughly in half. Substantively, this smaller effect size is akin to a difference between Mexico in 1992 to its late 1990s emerging democracy version.

Model 3 also examines mixed regimes, but adds $\Delta Russia\ Influence$ and $Russia\ Influence_{t-1}$ to account for Russia as an illiberal alternative major power. The results for $\Delta US\ Influence$ and $US\ Influence_{t-1}$ are the same as the previous model; both have positive effects. In contrast, $\Delta Russia\ Influence$ and $Russia\ Influence_{t-1}$ are each negative, though about half the size of the US effects. The 95 percent credible interval for $\Delta Russia\ Influence$ includes zero—ranging from -.011 to .001—though it is negative in approximately 94% of draws, giving relatively high confidence in inferring a negative effect. $Russia\ Influence_{t-1}$ is also negative and the credible interval excludes zero. The error correction rate is similar to that of Model 2, with high autocorrelation between periods. The long-run effect of a change in US influence is similar to the previous model. The long-run effect of a positive change in Russian influence is a reduction in democracy of .04, with a negative estimate in over 99.9% of draws from the posterior.

Legal institutions. Table 3 displays the results for four models comparing the impact of changes in US and Russian influence on the domestic legal institutional practices of human rights protections (Models 1 and 2) and rule of law (Models 3 and 4). Models 1 and 3 report the changes in US influence, the lagged level of US influence, and the error correction rate (lagged dependent variable). Models 2 and 4 add the first difference and lagged value of Russian influence.

Models 1 and 2 show little evidence of an instantaneous effect on human rights protections from changes by either major power. Both models, however, find that the lagged level of major-power influence, and the lagged level of human rights protections, have significant effects. Both US and Russian influence are positive, while the error correction rate is close to zero, suggesting that changes in major-power influence feed back through the dependent variable to produce long-run effects. The results bear this out: changes in US influence are positively associated with relatively large long-run effects. Surprisingly, changes in Russian

Table 3: Effect of Changes in Major-power Influence on Protégé Domestic Practices

	Human Rights Protections		Judicial Independence	
Δ US Influence	.001	.004	.000	.001
	[-.008, .010]	[-.003, .010]	[-.001, .002]	[-.001, .002]
US Influence _{<i>t</i>-1}	.007	.011	.001	.001
	[.003, .012]	[.007, .015]	[.001, .002]	[.000, .002]
Δ Russia Influence		.001		-.002
		[-.010, .011]		[-.003, -.000]
Russia Influence _{<i>t</i>-1}		.009		-.000
		[.004, .013]		[-.001, .001]
Dependent Variable _{<i>t</i>-1}	-.019	-.020	-.010	-.009
	[-.023, -.015]	[-.023, -.016]	[-.012, -.008]	[-.012, -.006]
Long-run Effect				
US Influence	.387	.542	.120	.121
	[.148, .645]	[.341, .759]	[.050, .212]	[.046, .221]
Russia Influence		.435		-.009
		[.200, .692]		[-.087, .067]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	7738	7738	7693	7693

Note: Median and 95% credible interval (in braces) summarize the posterior distribution estimated from a Bayesian error correction model with 50,000 MCMCs after 500,000 burn-in and thinning of 100 for models 1 and 2, and 100,000 MCMCs after 1,500,000 burn-in and thinning of 200 for models 3 and 4. Control variables are: *GDP/capita*, *democracy*, *protests*, *civil war*, *external threat*, and *population*. Long-run effects are constructed from the MCMCs as the negative ratio of the coefficient on lagged influence to the coefficient on the lagged dependent variable (long-run multiplier: $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$).

influence yield directionally similar, albeit smaller, long-run effects.

A possible explanation for this unexpected result is that the baseline level of human rights protections for protégés with relatively high US influence is greater than that of Russia’s protégés. Since an ECM looks at changes in, rather than levels of, the dependent variable, it may be the case that greater major-power influence contributes to enhanced stability which then prevents the worst levels of human rights violations, rather than increases in major-power influence directly improving human rights across the board. In support of this interpretation, the conditional mean for human rights of a country with a US influence score of .5 or greater (e.g., conducting a joint military exercise and receiving arms transfers) is just under one standard deviation higher than that for a country with a Russia influence score of .5 or greater. This descriptive analysis—combined with the results in Table 3—suggests that while there are clear baseline differences in human rights practices between US and Russian protégés, decreases in major-power influence worsen human rights conditions.

Models 3 and 4 demonstrate that while there is little evidence of a short-term impact of US influence on judicial independence, there is a positive relationship between the lagged level of US influence and judicial independence. The reverse holds for Russian influence: there is a small negative relationship between changes in influence and judicial independence, but there is no evidence of a relationship between the lagged level of influence and judicial independence. The error correction rate is again close to zero, indicating strong feedback processes. The long-run effect of increases (decreases) in US influence is relatively large gains (losses) in judicial independence. There is little evidence, however, for an impact of Russian influence on long-term judicial independence.

International economic policies. Next, I turn to the impact of major-power influence on trade openness and US trade share, in Table 4. Trade openness captures the liberal principle of trade in general, whereas US trade share measures the specific benefits for one major power. I focus on US trade share, rather than Russian trade share, owing to a lack of reliable data during the Soviet period.

Each of the models estimates an error correction rate near zero, indicating significant autocorrelation in the time series. Models 1 and 2 show limited evidence, however, of a short- or long-run impact of changes in major-power influence on trade openness.²¹ Models 3 and 4 show a much clearer pattern: the US trade share is significantly impacted. As the dependent variable is logged, the coefficient can be interpreted as an approximate percent change in the outcome. A one-unit increase (one-unit decrease) in US influence is associated with roughly a 4 percent increase (4 percent decrease) in US trade share. Similarly, an increase (decrease) in Russian influence leads to an approximate 2.5 percent decrease (2.5 percent increase) in US trade share. Taken together, Table 4 provides little evidence that a decrease in US influence changes a minor power’s overall reliance on trade, but does reduce the share of that trade conducted with the US.

To calculate the long-run impact of a change in US influence on the US share of a

²¹The long-run impact is negative in 88.3% and 85.1% of draws, respectively.

Table 4: Effect of Changes in Major-power Influence on Protégé Trade.

Dependent Variable:	Trade GDP	Trade GDP	US Trade Total Trade	US Trade Total Trade
Δ US Influence	.004 [-.006, .014]	.004 [-.007, .014]	.041 [.019, .065]	.039 [.014, .063]
US Influence $_{t-1}$	-.004 [-.010, .002]	-.003 [-.010, .003]	.026 [.012, .041]	.017 [.002, .033]
Δ Russia Influence		-.008 [-.020, .004]		-.027 [-.056, .003]
Russia Influence $_{t-1}$		.000 [-.007, .008]		-.051 [-.066, -.037]
Dependent Variable $_{t-1}$	-.038 [-.045, -.031]	-.038 [-.045, -.031]	-.072 [-.080, -.063]	-.081 [-.090, -.072]
Long-run Effect				
US Influence	-.100 [-.270, .064]	-.090 [-.266, .081]	.368 [.171, .569]	.212 [.030, .408]
Russia Influence		.004 [-.200, .202]		-.631 [-.805, -.461]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	6086	6086	7383	7383

Note: Median and 95% credible interval (in braces) summarize the posterior distribution estimated from a Bayesian error correction model with 50,000 retained posterior draws following 100,000 burn-in iterations and thinning every 50th draw. Control variables are: *GDP/capita*, *GDP*, *democracy*, *human rights protections*, and *external threat*. All controls include their difference and one-year lag. Long-run effects are constructed from the MCMCs as the negative ratio of the coefficient on lagged influence to the coefficient on the lagged dependent variable (long-run multiplier: $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$).

minor power's trade, the simple percent-change approximation no longer suffices; instead, the formula $\% \Delta y = 100[\exp(\beta) - 1]$ is used. Applied to Model 3, a one-unit increase in US influence is associated with an approximate 44 percent increase in US trade share. The inverse, a decrease in US influence, however, would have a negative coefficient, producing a 31 percent decrease in the US share of trade. Model 4 reveals a result in the same direction, but smaller in scope. Here, a one-unit increase in US influence would lead to a 24 percent increase in the US share of trade over the long run, while a similarly sized decrease would produce a reduction in US share of total trade of roughly 19 percent. An increase in Russian influence would have a long-run effect of reducing the US trade share by nearly 47 percent.

Foreign policy alignment. Finally, Table 5 examines the impact of a change in US influence on a minor power's foreign policy alignment with the US and with Russia. Protégé foreign policy positions appear fairly stable over time; the error correction rates indicate

high temporal dependence, though the coefficients for Russian alignment (Models 3 and 4) are lower than those for US alignment (Models 1 and 2). Models 1 and 2 focus on US foreign policy alignment, with the former using an alliance-based measure and the latter based on UN voting. Both show that increases in US influence correspond to increased alignment in both the short and long run, with $\Delta US\ Influence$ positive in over 89% of draws using the alliance-based measure and over 99.9% of draws with the UN voting measure. The LRM is positive in over 97.7% of draws with the alliance-based measure and over 92.5% of draws for the UN voting measure. Increases in Russian influence are negative in the short-run for the alliance-based measure,²² and both the short and long run for the measure based on UN voting. Substantively, the short-run effects of changes in US influence are very small for both the alliance- and UN-based measures, while the long-run effects are moderate for the alliance-based measure²³—the coefficient of .163 represents a change of 57% of one standard deviation from the mean—but only a 2 percentage point change in the share of UN voting agreement.

Models 3 and 4 display foreign policy alignment with Russia, using the same two measures. In this case, increases in Russian influence exert both short- and long-run positive effects on alignment. Moreover, these effects are larger, in substantive terms, than those of increases in US influence. For the alliance-based measure, the long-run effect for Russian influence is just over one standard deviation, while the difference in agreement in UN voting is over four times greater. Of course, the inverse is that decreases in Russian influence are associated with similarly sized dis-alignment in a minor power’s foreign policy. Conversely, changes in US influence have virtually no short-term effect on a minor power’s alignment toward Russian foreign policy. There is also only moderate evidence of a long-term effect, with the LRM for the alliance- and UN voting-based measures being negative in over 82.6% and 83.4% of draws, respectively.

The differences in the substantive effects of changes in major-power influence and protégé

²²The long-run effect is negative in only 75% of draws.

²³The alliance-based measure varies from a minimum of -.33 to a maximum .9.

Table 5: Effect of Changes in Major-power Influence on Protégé Foreign Policy Alignment.

Dependent Variable:	US Align. (Alliance)	US Align. (UN Votes)	Russia Align. (Alliance)	Russia Align. (UN Votes)
Δ US Influence	.001 [-.001, .003]	.012 [.006, .017]	.000 [-.003, .003]	.000 [-.006, .007]
US Influence $_{t-1}$	.001 [.000, .003]	.003 [-.001, .006]	-.001 [-.003, .001]	-.002 [-.006, .002]
Δ Russia Influence	-.004 [-.006, -.001]	-.009 [-.016, -.002]	.032 [.028, .035]	.032 [.024, .039]
Russia Influence $_{t-1}$	-.000 [-.001, .001]	-.005 [-.009, -.002]	.011 [.009, .014]	.017 [.013, .020]
Dependent Variable $_{t-1}$	-.008 [-.011, -.005]	-.147 [-.157, -.136]	-.061 [-.068, -.055]	-.176 [-.188, -.165]
Long-run Effect				
US Influence	.163 [-.003, .330]	.018 [-.007, .042]	-.014 [-.046, .016]	-.011 [-.032, .011]
Russia Influence	-.050 [-.203, .104]	-.037 [-.060, -.014]	.186 [.156, .216]	.095 [.074, .116]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	7945	7224	7945	7222

Note: Median and 95% credible interval (in braces) summarize the posterior distribution estimated from a Bayesian error correction model with 40,000 retained posterior draws following 75,000 burn-in iterations and thinning every 50th draw. Control variables are: *GDP/capita*, *GDP*, *democracy*, and *external threat*. Long-run effects are constructed from the MCMCs as the negative ratio of the coefficient on lagged influence to the coefficient on the lagged dependent variable (long-run multiplier: $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$).

foreign policy alignment, across the US- and Russian-led networks, may reflect differences in how such hierarchical networks are organized and structured (McManus and Nieman 2019), or whether a network is led by either a liberal or illiberal power (Lanoszka 2013; Chyzh and Labzina 2018). In particular, there is likely variation in whether carrots are withdrawn or sticks applied by major powers when a minor power acts counter to the existing hierarchical arrangement (Lanoszka 2013; Truckos 2021). In either case, the results of Table 5 indicate that when support is withdrawn, minor powers tend to drift away from the major power.

Overall, the results summarized in the four tables illustrate the impact of variation in US and Russian influence on protégés' domestic institutions and practices, as well as their foreign economic and security policies. Reductions in major-power influence sometimes lead to a short-term turn against the major power's milieu goals, e.g., democracy and trade, offering some support for Hypothesis 1. Yet, even when there is not an immediate shift, there is strong evidence of a long-term backlash against the major power's milieu goals across

the range of policy outcomes—consistent with Hypothesis 2. Finally, the repercussions are further heightened when a rival major power is able to step in to fill the void; this result is consistent with Hypothesis 3.

Other Major Powers

The previous section demonstrates how changes in US and Russian influence affect the degree to which protégés adhere to their patron’s milieu goals. Here, I consider whether changes in influence by other liberal and illiberal major powers similarly affect variation in protégé behavior over both the short and long term. Specifically, I look at the effect of changes in influence by the UK, France, and China on all minor powers in the international system. I treat the UK and France as holding liberal milieu goals and China as promoting illiberal goals. In the case of the UK and France, I use the same 1950–2010 sample; however, I restrict the analysis to the time period after the end of the Cold War (post 1990) in the case of China, to reflect its re-emergence as a global actor.

The results of this analysis are presented in Table 6 and are broadly similar to those reported in the previous section. The liberal major powers, the UK and France, exhibit effects similar to those of the US, while the illiberal major power, China, exhibits effects similar to those of Russia. Increases in the UK’s and France’s influence are associated with short- and long-run increases in democratic reform and human rights protections.²⁴ In contrast, increases in China’s influence are associated with negative short- and long-term effects for democratic reform and human rights.²⁵ Increases in influence by all three major powers are associated with short- and long-term increases in bilateral trade and foreign policy alignment.²⁶

Together, the results from this and the previous section demonstrate the impact of major-

²⁴Increases in $\Delta Influence$ for the UK and the LRM for France are positive in over 97.1% and 94.1% of draws, respectively, for *democracy*. In the case of *human rights*, $\Delta Influence$ for the UK and France are positive in over 92.9% and 97.6% of draws, respectively.

²⁵Increases in $\Delta Influence$ for China are negative for *human rights* in over 94.4% of draws and, surprisingly, positive for *judicial independence* in over 91.4% of draws.

²⁶For *foreign policy alignment*, increases in $\Delta Influence$ for China are positive in over 96.8% of draws.

Table 6: Effect of Changes in UK, France, and China Influence on Protégé Policies

Dependent Variable:	Democracy	Human Rights	Judicial Independence	Trade GDP	MP Trade Total Trade	MP Align. (Alliance)
Major Power: United Kingdom						
Δ Influence	.005	.006	-.000	-.009	.015	.010
Influence _{t-1}	[-.000, .010]	[-.002, .014]	[-.001, .001]	[-.018, .001]	[-.004, .034]	[.007, .012]
Dependent Variable _{t-1}	.007	.011	-.000	-.000	.025	.011
	[.003, .011]	[.005, .018]	[-.001, .001]	[-.008, .007]	[.010, .039]	[.008, .013]
Long-run Effect	-.072	-.020	-.009	-.038	-.080	-.026
	[-.082, -.061]	[-.024, -.017]	[-.011, -.006]	[-.045, -.031]	[-.089, -.072]	[-.031, -.021]
	.097	.561	-.040	-.010	.305	.400
	[.038, .158]	[.269, .866]	[-.152, .065]	[-.213, .192]	[.120, .491]	[.326, .477]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	4154	7738	7693	6086	7383	7945
Major Power: France						
Δ Influence	.001	.007	.000	.001	.017	.006
Influence _{t-1}	[-.003, .005]	[-.000, .014]	[-.001, .001]	[-.006, .009]	[.000, .034]	[.003, .008]
Dependent Variable _{t-1}	.003	.008	.000	.000	.034	.005
	[-.001, .007]	[.002, .014]	[-.001, .001]	[-.007, .007]	[.020, .049]	[.003, .008]
Long-run Effect	-.071	-.019	-.010	-.038	-.075	-.022
	[-.081, -.060]	[-.023, -.015]	[-.012, -.008]	[-.045, -.031]	[-.083, -.068]	[-.027, -.018]
	.046	.408	.004	.001	.455	.244
	[-.012, .104]	[.086, .740]	[-.083, .082]	[-.192, .187]	[.264, .641]	[.153, .330]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	4154	7738	7693	6086	7383	7945
Major Power: China						
Δ Influence	-.009	-.011	.000	-.020	.049	.003
Influence _{t-1}	[-.015, -.002]	[-.025, .002]	[-.001, .002]	[-.035, -.006]	[.022, .076]	[-.000, .007]
Dependent Variable _{t-1}	-.011	-.020	.001	-.010	.049	.001
	[-.018, -.004]	[-.034, -.007]	[-.000, .002]	[-.026, .006]	[.020, .078]	[-.003, .005]
Long-run Effect	-.085	-.030	-.004	-.037	-.057	-.007
	[-.102, -.069]	[-.036, -.025]	[-.007, -.000]	[-.047, -.026]	[-.070, -.044]	[-.014, -.000]
	-.129	-.675	.231	-.285	.853	.182
	[-.218, -.050]	[-1.137, -.236]	[-.116, 2.531]	[-.762, .151]	[.355, 1.322]	[-1.317, 2.066]
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Number of Observations	1791	3259	3253	3083	3067	3277

Note: Median and 95% credible interval (in braces) summarize the posterior distribution estimated from a Bayesian error correction model with 50,000 retained posterior draws following 100,000 burn-in iterations and thinning every 100th draw for model 1, 50,000 retained posterior draws following 250,000 burn-in iterations and thinning every 50th draw for models 2–6. The sample for *democracy* includes only mixed regimes. All samples for China are restricted to after 1990. Control variables are the same as for the dependent variables in Tables 2–5. Long-run effects are constructed from the MCMCs as the negative ratio of the coefficient on lagged influence to the coefficient on the lagged dependent variable (long-run multiplier: $-\frac{\beta_1}{\alpha_1}$).

power influence and withdrawal. On average, increases in influence from a liberal major power correspond to improvements in democracy and human rights in the minor power, an increased share of the minor power's trade, and more aligned foreign policies. Minor powers that lose the support of a liberal major power experience democratic backsliding, a deterioration of human rights, and a diversification of trade and foreign policy alignment away from the liberal major power.

Increased engagement with an illiberal power yields declines in democracy, less trade

with liberal powers, and a more aligned foreign policy, while decreased engagement leads to the inverse. The main exception is human rights, where Russian influence is also associated with higher long-run protections, suggesting that some forms of major-power support may stabilize state capacity even when the patron’s broader milieu goals are illiberal.

Identifying Assumptions and Causal Interpretation

The ECM estimates reported above are consistent with the theoretical expectation that reductions in major-power influence alter protégé behavior in both the short and long run. Interpreting these estimates causally, however, requires assumptions beyond the dynamic specification itself. Like other regression-based approaches, the ECM relies on a selection-on-observables logic (see Keele 2015). The key identifying question is whether changes in major-power influence can be treated as conditionally independent of contemporaneous unobserved changes in protégé outcomes, once the model accounts for prior outcomes, prior influence, and observed covariates. I evaluate this claim through five assumptions: sequential exogeneity, no anticipation, correct dynamic specification, weak exogeneity of major-power influence, and no unmodeled interference across units. The relevant diagnostic tests are summarized here and reported in full in the Online Appendix.

The first assumption is sequential exogeneity. In this context, sequential exogeneity means that, after conditioning on the observed history included in the model, unobserved shocks to protégé outcomes do not also determine contemporaneous changes in major-power influence (Angrist and Pischke 2009, 243–244; Keele 2015, 322). This assumption does not require major-power influence to be independent of all prior protégé behavior. Major powers may respond to observed prior outcomes, prior support levels, and other modeled covariates. This assumption rules out unmodeled feedback that leaves the current change in major-power influence correlated with the remaining error term.

In this setting, the main threat is reverse causation: protégé domestic institutions or foreign-policy behavior may change first, prompting the major power to reduce support.

The theory developed above mitigates this concern by emphasizing the asymmetric nature of the major power relationship with protégés. Protégés may hedge, signal loyalty, diversify ties, seek marginal adjustments, or offer policy concessions to preserve support, but they rarely have the leverage to compel the patron to maintain the relationship once the patron’s domestic or geopolitical calculus changes. Changes in support are therefore more likely to originate with the major power than with the protégé. I also evaluate this assumption empirically. I examine whether shifts in protégés’ domestic coalitions predict subsequent changes in major-power influence. They do not. By contrast, changes in major-power ruling coalitions and geopolitical context do predict subsequent changes in major-power influence, consistent with the theoretical claim that change is primarily patron-driven.²⁷

A related concern is anticipatory adjustment. If protégés foresee future reductions in support and adjust their behavior before the measured withdrawal occurs, the estimated effect could partly reflect behavior in anticipation of treatment. I assess this possibility by estimating models with leads of major-power influence. For the institutional outcomes—democracy, human rights, and rule of law—the lead terms are not statistically significant, suggesting little evidence of anticipatory adjustment. For the economic and foreign-policy outcomes, the main estimates remain stable after including lead terms, but some leads are statistically significant. This pattern suggests timing ambiguity: trade and foreign-policy behavior may begin to adjust before the measured decline in support, or annual data may assign a gradual change in patron commitment to a later observation year. I therefore treat these estimates as qualified causal evidence—consistent with the proposed mechanism, but less cleanly timed than the institutional results.

The third assumption concerns dynamic specification. The model must include enough of the relevant history of the outcome and explanatory variable to capture the dynamic process. Because both major-power influence and the outcomes are highly persistent, I first evaluate

²⁷I measure changes in both protégé and major power ruling coalitions using data from Mattes, Leeds and Matsemura (2016), while changes in geopolitical context are constructed based on changes in a protégé’s relationship with a rival major power.

the time-series properties of the variables. Though the presence of a unit root cannot be ruled out for several outcome variables²⁸, the key explanatory variable of major-power influence is stationary, eliminating concerns of cointegration (Enders 2010, 373). Moreover, the outcome variable is first-differenced, so that the estimated equation is specified in stationary terms.²⁹ I also find evidence consistent with the temporal specification of the main variables. Lag-order diagnostics support the dynamic structure used in the baseline models.

The fourth assumption concerns weak exogeneity of major-power influence for the single-equation ECM. Substantively, the concern is that major-power influence may adjust in response to prior protégé outcomes, in which case the treatment process would be jointly determined with the outcome process rather than plausibly modeled as conditionally independent.³⁰ This assumption is key for estimating valid long-run effects. I assess this concern by estimating marginal models of changes in major-power influence and testing whether lagged outcome terms predict subsequent changes in influence (Enders 2010: 371; Linn, Lebo, and Webb 2026: 113–117). The test therefore asks whether the treatment process responds systematically to earlier protégé behavior once prior influence and the relevant controls are taken into account. The results provide little evidence that major-power influence adjusts systematically in response to prior protégé outcomes.

Finally, causal interpretation requires that treatment in one unit does not affect outcomes in other units in unmodeled ways, i.e., the stable unit treatment value assumption (SUTVA) (Imbens and Rubin 2015; Keele 2015). This is a particularly important concern because major powers may reduce support for multiple protégés at once, and protégés may respond not only to their own support relationship but also to changes in the broader network.

²⁸Dickey-Fuller tests show that the null hypothesis of a unit root cannot be rejected for *democracy*, *human rights protections*, *judicial independence*, and *trade as a percent GDP*.

²⁹An ECM can be used in either scenario: with jointly stationary data as well as when the outcome is integrated outcome and the explanatory variable is stationary (De Boef and Keele 2008; Keele, Linn and Webb 2016; Linn, Lebo and Webb 2026). Moreover, using a single estimation strategy allows for a consistent presentation and an interpretation of the relationship between major-power influence and the various outcomes.

³⁰More technically, a variable is weakly exogenous if: (1) the parameters of interest in a conditional model do not depend on the parameter values from the marginal model, and (2) the parameters are unrestricted across the models (Engle, Hendry and Richard 1983; Linn, Lebo and Webb 2026, 114–115).

To address this possibility, I estimate spatial autoregressive models using a spatial weights matrix in which protégés are connected in proportion to their joint embeddedness in the same major-power support network. The main results are robust to this alternative specification.

These diagnostics clarify the inferential status of the results. The ECM does not provide experimental identification, and the assumptions required for causal interpretation cannot be proven definitively with observational data. For the institutional outcomes, however, the theoretical argument and empirical diagnostics provide strong support for a causal interpretation within the limits of observational panel analysis. The evidence is consistent with patron-driven changes in support, shows no meaningful anticipatory adjustment, supports the dynamic specification, satisfies weak exogeneity for the long-run relationship, and is robust to models that address cross-sectional dependence.

For the economic and foreign-policy outcomes, the diagnostics are somewhat more mixed because some lead terms are statistically significant. The concern is temporal ordering: some adjustment may precede the year in which disengagement is observed, especially for outcomes that are flexible and forward-looking. The main estimates, however, remain stable after including the leads, and the remaining diagnostics support the dynamic specification, weak exogeneity, and robustness to cross-sectional dependence. I therefore interpret these findings as qualified causal evidence: they are consistent with the proposed mechanism, but the timing of adjustment is less clean than for the institutional outcomes.

Conclusion

I argue that major power disengagement has substantial consequences for minor powers' behavior. The results bear this out across a wide range of domestic institutions and policy practices: in both the short and long run, minor powers tend to drift away from the patron's milieu goals. These shifts are especially pronounced when a rival major power steps in to replace the old patron's influence with its own, pushing the protégé further along a new

ideological and strategic trajectory.

The changes do not affect only the protégés; they also impose real costs on the major power itself. When a major power abandons relatively low-cost tools of influence—such as long-standing security ties and diplomatic engagement—it may later find that achieving the same policy outcomes requires much more expensive forms of coercion or inducement. States whose preferences and policies already lean toward those of the patron require far fewer material incentives to join military coalitions (Henke 2017) or to host troops or intelligence assets (Nieman et al. 2021; Carson, Metz and Poast 2025). Likewise, publics that view a major power favorably tend to be more accepting of its foreign policy and less likely to mobilize against requests for support (Henke 2018; Allen et al. 2020, 2023). Once those reservoirs of goodwill and habit are depleted, recreating them is costly and uncertain.

Taken together, the results paint a sobering picture for the future of the LIO. US President Trump has chosen to erode and undermine ties with aligned protégés (US White House 2025). Because all major powers depend on partners to sustain their political orders (Mastanduno 2019), the likely consequence is that the US will face a world less receptive to its values, less responsive to its preferences, and more expensive to shape when it tries. Some traditional partners, such as Canada, are already seeking to reduce their dependence on US armaments (Gillies 2025). Other liberal powers, such as Germany and Japan, are expanding their military capabilities (Stanley-Becker 2025; Yamaguchi 2024). While Washington has long called for greater burden-sharing, a natural corollary is that these partners will be less willing to accept a junior role and will insist on greater voice in how their resources are used.

Finally, the full implications of US withdrawal for global order will unfold only gradually. A future administration may attempt to repair or rebuild the damaged order—but doing so would require renewed cooperation from the very states that were recently sidelined, and such trust is not easy or quickly restored. Unless other liberal powers can effectively substitute for the US in their relations with abandoned protégés, while simultaneously constraining the expansion of rival illiberal powers such as China and Russia, liberalism is likely to recede—

unevenly, but perceptibly—across the system. Under such a scenario, the LIO may not vanish altogether, but its depth and scope are likely to contract sharply.

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